

The Coherence Machine

When Systems Stop Learning From Reality

Reality Drift Framework — Representational Systems Brief #5

A. Jacobs

The Basic Pattern

Healthy systems remain answerable to reality.

Drifted systems become answerable to their own representations.

The transition is gradual.

Institutions establish categories.

Media amplifies them.

Metrics quantify them.

Public perception accepts them.

Institutions then respond to that perception rather than to the underlying conditions.

The basic sequence is:

institution → media → metrics → public perception → institutional response → institution

The loop becomes self-reinforcing.

Reality no longer provides the primary corrective feedback.

What Is the Coherence Machine?

The Coherence Machine is a closed representational system.

Each component validates the next.

Institutions define what matters.

Media determines what becomes visible.

Metrics quantify what is visible.

Public perception accepts the quantified representation.

Institutions then interpret that public perception as evidence that their original assumptions were correct.

The cycle begins again.

Every part of the system remains internally consistent.

The system appears increasingly coherent.

How Reality Becomes Optional

The loop does not require reality to disappear.

It only requires representations to become sufficient for decision-making.

An institution reads reports instead of conditions.

Journalists report indicators instead of direct observation.

Dashboards replace field experience.

Public opinion forms around mediated representations.

Decision-makers respond to those representations.

Reality still exists.

It simply becomes unnecessary for the operation of the loop.

Why Drift Accelerates

Every cycle strengthens the representations created by the previous cycle.

Policies generate metrics.

Metrics generate headlines.

Headlines shape perception.

Perception justifies new policies.

Each round makes the system more internally stable.

Each round weakens the need to verify against reality.

The system becomes increasingly confident because every layer agrees with every other layer.

The Missing Feedback Loop

Healthy systems contain negative feedback.

Reality interrupts mistaken representations.

Unexpected outcomes force revision.

People closest to the conditions can correct the model.

The Coherence Machine weakens those interruptions.

External correction becomes noise.

Contradictory evidence becomes anecdotal.

The representation becomes more authoritative than observation.

The system no longer learns primarily from reality.

It learns from itself.

Reality Drift

Within the **Reality Drift framework**, the Coherence Machine is one of the primary mechanisms through which Reality Drift develops.

The institution becomes accountable to its reports.

The reports become accountable to its metrics.

The metrics become accountable to its objectives.

Every representation remains internally consistent.

The only thing that no longer has authority is reality itself.

This is why systems can become increasingly confident while becoming progressively less aligned.

Why It Appears Everywhere

The same loop appears across governments, corporations, healthcare, education, financial markets, digital platforms, AI systems, and online culture.

Different organizations.

Different technologies.

The same structural pattern.

Representations begin validating other representations until external reality is no longer required to keep the system operating.

The Core Principle

Reality does not disappear when systems drift.

It simply loses its role as the primary source of correction.

The system becomes increasingly coherent because every representation confirms the next.

Coherence becomes evidence.

Agreement becomes validation.

Internal consistency becomes mistaken for truth.

Reality Drift begins when systems stop responding to conditions and start responding to representations of conditions.

The most dangerous systems are not the ones that disagree with reality. They are the ones that no longer need to consult it.

Keywords: the coherence machine, closed feedback loops, representational feedback, institutional feedback loops, self-reinforcing systems, recursive validation, proxy optimization, reality versus representation, semantic fidelity, institutional drift, closed-loop systems, systems thinking, Reality Drift, A. Jacobs